His disdain for the Mumbai Police came through when Niraj created a Twitter handle (@giyu44) to mock the arrests they had made in the Bulli Bai case. "You have arrested the wrong person, slumbai police... I am the creator of #BulliBaiApp... Got nothing to do with the two innocents whom u arrested, release them asap," he tweeted. Mumbai Police had earlier made three arrests: Shweta Singh, 18, a 12th-pass orphan from Rudrapur, Uttarakhand; Patna's Vishal Kumar Jha, 21, studying at Bangalore's Dayanand Sagar College of Engineering; and Mayank Rawat from Uttarakhand, also 21, doing BSc in Delhi's Zakir Hussain College. Police sources say Niraj has admitted to communicating with the three over social media, claimting that they were mere followers of his app, not creators.

Their social profiles had strong overlaps: humble, downhome backgrounds, often quiet personalities. Shweta, one of four siblings, lost her father to Covid in 2020—cancer had claimed her mother in 2011. The family survives on a monthly income of Rs 13,000, and she was preparing to study engineering. Precisely the step in life that brought about an aloofness in Vishal's behaviour, his parents say. Once an NCC cadet, friends, family and neighbours in Patna remember him for his chess and carrom skills. "Nothing that even remotely connects him to any kind of radicalism. No hatred towards any community. I've not seen him applying even tilak...he used to read science-related things on his laptop," says a family member.

Sulli Deals may have been a different app, but the prototype of a reticent geek-gone-mutant was visible again when, based on Niraj's interrogation, Delhi Police arrested its alleged mastermind: 25-year-old Omkareshwar Thakur, an Indore-based freelance code developer who was to get married on April 20. Everyone again speaks of a shy, unassuming boy who hardly spoke to anyone. A Muslim family in the neighbourhood can't believe "that mild-mannered boy" could have held such hatred for their community.

Omkareshwar's family—natives of Darbhanga, Bihar—have been living in 'New York City', a gated township in Indore, for 32 years. He earned a BCA degree from a local institute in 2018. His father, Akhilesh Thakur, works for a plastic company, brother Mandaleshwar in a software firm. "We are a middle-class family busy earning a livelihood. We don't have any connection with any right-wing Hindu group," says Akhilesh. The prospective bride's family wasn't taking any chances—the wedding is now off.

What connects these youngsters with decent academic records and ordinary backgrounds? The roiling interface of technology, modern politics and minds too raw to comprehend the world they grow up in—living mundane lives, made poorer by a utilitarian education model that leaves no space for learning anything enlivened by empathy, they find release in the dark waters of social media. Their technical skills, coupled with a combustible mix of outer and inner violence, makes them precisely the most dangerous recruits to radicalism. It's a pattern seen across all denominations of radicalism—in 2015, three science students from Hyderabad were nabbed while allegedly on their way to join the terrorist group Islamic state (IS) in Afghanistan.

Social scientist Dipankar Gupta puts his finger on that sense of relative deprivation felt by young, educated members of an alienated middle class. "They can touch what they aspire for but fail to grasp it. And the only explanation they have for it is that those who have succeeded have done so primarily on account of being well-connected and privileged, not because they are deserving. Sadly, this is not entirely incorrect. This is why many easily identify with the *naamdar vs kaamdar* binary as examples of its legitimacy abound. They become open to all kinds of ideological prescriptions and quick-fix answers," explains Gupta.

Others trace it to the current sociopolitical environment where even political leaders publicly mouth venom against certain communities—and succeed because they tap into a perceived sense of injustice. "A large section of Hindus feels wronged. The earlier generations were tolerant, but the youngsters are getting impatient, perhaps because on social media and in the political spectrum, they find acceptance of their feelings—justified or not," says Joyanta Borbora, professor of sociology in Dibrugarh University, who specialises in criminology.

None of those arrested has admitted to links with any organisation, but cyber experts say extremist right-wing groups trawl social media for such youngsters and gradually brainwash them to create a whole army of hate campaigners. During interrogation, Omkareshwar reportedly admitted that he was a member of Tradmahasabha, an informal online group of traditionalists or 'Trads'. That's one of two groups online Hindu radicals are divided into—the other is 'Raita'. Trads see themselves in the Smarta lineage, believing in the caste system and Brahminical supremacy. They are not aligned to any political party. Raitas mostly support the RSS-BJP, supporting ideas like *ghar wapasi*. The Trads, who hold those ideas to be anti-Hindu, troll even Dalits. The creators of both apps were Trads—a right wing that even the right wing is giving right of way to. ■

with Rahul Noronha and Amitabh Srivastava

WHAT ARE BULLI BAI AND SULLI DEALS?

BULLI BAI: 'Bulli Bai' was an online app that put several Muslim women–journalists, activists and others–up for an online 'auction'. Hosted on GitHub, a Microsoft-owned software-sharing platform, this app was developed in November and went public on December 31. There was no actual sale involved on either apps; the purpose was to degrade, humiliate and harass Muslim women

SULLI DEALS: Similar to Bulli Bai, this app surfaced on GitHub in July 2021. It also targeted Muslim women. The app creator soon deleted it, and no action was taken by the police at the time